balancing to examine long-term trends in India's policy, while we apply the narrow definition in order to classify India's current take on China.

We have in recent years seen a growing academic literature addressing the limitations of the balancing–bandwagoning dichotomy to explain state behaviour. One concept put forward is that of soft balancing. According to Pape, soft balancing "relies on non-military tools, but it aims to have a real, if indirect, effect on the military prospects of a superior state."[42] Soft balancing has been described as a preferred strategy when the state does not fear a threat to its physical security but is concerned about the adverse effects rising powers can cause on the state's general political and economic position.[43] It is further characterised by limited arms build-up and more informal ad hoc security understandings among affected states short of formal alliances.[44] Soft balancing is furthermore viewed as the early stages of hard balancing behaviour, as states that coordinate positions on minor issues could build the trust needed to develop more ambitious counterbalancing behaviour.[45] However, soft balancing has been criticised on the simple assumption that states either balance or they don't. It has been argued that it is the link to balance-of-power theory that gives soft balancing this dramatic punch and, if that link is taken away, "soft balancing collapses into a portentous-sounding term to describe conventional policy disputes and diplomatic bargaining."[46] Although the soft balancing literature is useful to address nuances in balancing behaviour short of hard balancing, we prefer to use the concept of hedging to examine changes and trends in India's behaviour along the balancing–bandwagoning spectrum.

India is engaging China on a number of issues. China is now India's largest trading partner,[47] and New Delhi and Beijing share common views with regard to reforming several global institutions, including increasing the voting shares of